

RALLYING FOR REFORM
PDP president Mehbooba Mufti addressing a public meeting in Tral, Sept. 13

PDP HAS SEEN A MINOR REJIG AS ITS LEADERS RETURN TO THE FOLD, BUT GOING BY ITS PERFORMANCE IN THE RECENT LS ELECTION, IT'S GOING TO BE AN UPHILL TASK TO BE A WINNER

CHOKING THE TERROR TAP

The BJP in its manifesto claims that its policy of "zero tolerance against terrorism" has seen organised stone-pelting incidents and hartals come down from 1,328 in 2018 to nearly none last year. The state police cracked down heavily on militants, their families and associates, putting many in jail, and even terminating the services of government employees suspected of helping them. "In doing so," says a senior state police officer, "we succeeded in wiping out the fear of the gun and ending the separatist strategy of boycotting elections by getting cross-party consensus on closing the space on the Pakistan-backed agenda." Official data from J&K Police shows 818 terrorists were taken out since 2019—the 2023 figure of 73, the lowest in a decade, confirms the choking of that pipeline. So does the 53 per cent dip in encounters, with casualties among security forces restricted to 30, the lowest in 10 years. Civilian deaths in encounters or terror attacks, too, have plummeted by 68 per cent since 2019.

But while it may be true that Indian security forces have been able to eliminate many terrorist commanders and foot-soldiers and whittle down the graph of militancy in the Valley, Pakistan-backed entities have also changed tack and shifted the arena of attacks to the mountainous parts of Jammu, reactivating a two-decade-old refuge. Since October 2021, security forces have had 54 casualties, including two soldiers in Kishtwar on September 13, a day before Prime Minister Narendra Modi addressed a rally in neighbouring Doda district.

The BJP is also showcasing success on other fronts. Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha cites how Lal Chowk, once the epicentre of terror attacks and stone-pelting mobs, is presently thronging with tourists who can now enjoy a meal even at midnight without any restrictions. A record 21 million tourists visited the Union Territory last year, he says. Two-thirds of these though would have been pilgrims, say critics; not much has been done to encourage vacationing tourists.

On the development front, the BJP is citing the impressive strides made in road as well as rail connectivity in both Jammu and Kashmir. These include the Rs 14,000 crore Chenab railway bridge, the Rs 3,100 crore Banihal-Qazigund tunnel and the Rs 6,809 crore Zojila tunnel, besides the Rs 40,000 crore Delhi-Katra greenfield expressway. In terms of business, the BJP claims that its new industrial policy has led to the state receiving over Rs 1.26 lakh crore worth of investment proposals, of which Rs 6,624 crore has been realised, resulting in 550,000 jobs. Opposition parties, of course, scoff at such claims. Altaf Bukhari, president, Apni Party, which was once seen to have the BJP's backing, says, "There is no revolution in development—most of these infrastructure projects were started by earlier governments, the Centre just completed them. Kashmir is in a financial mess. There is no business, no money, no jobs, land prices have gone down 50 per cent. We have 16 lakh unemployed youth and postgraduates."

JAMMU HOLDS THE KEY

Hindu-dominated Jammu is the BJP's main strength. The party had won 25 seats here in 2014, enabling it to form a government in alliance with the PDP. This time, it is vital for the saffron party to win at least 30-35 out of Jammu's 43 seats if it hopes to form a government on its own. Overall, the BJP needs to secure a minimum of 46 of the 90 assembly seats on its own or with post-poll allies. In the general election in May, the BJP won two of J&K's five seats, both in Jammu, and the NC two of the three seats in the Valley. The big surprise was the massive victory of Engineer Rashid, the jailed leader of the Awami Ittehad Party (AIP) in Baramulla, defeating